HAAG Coworking Session SOP

Standard Operating Procedure for Student-Led Collaboration Sessions

1. Purpose

This procedure defines a repeatable process that HAAG researchers can use to increase cross-team interaction, awareness of ongoing work, and opportunities for networking and collaboration. The goal is to provide a low-pressure, consistent environment where participation is optional but adds value to its participants.

2. Intended Audience

This SOP is designed for HAAG students, researchers, admins or managers who want to host coworking sessions. No prior facilitation experience is required.

3. Overview

Each session follows a lightweight, repeatable structure:

1. Set up and announce the session
2. Run a short optional activity
3. Transition into coworking time
4. Observe participation and collect feedback
5. Iterate for future sessions

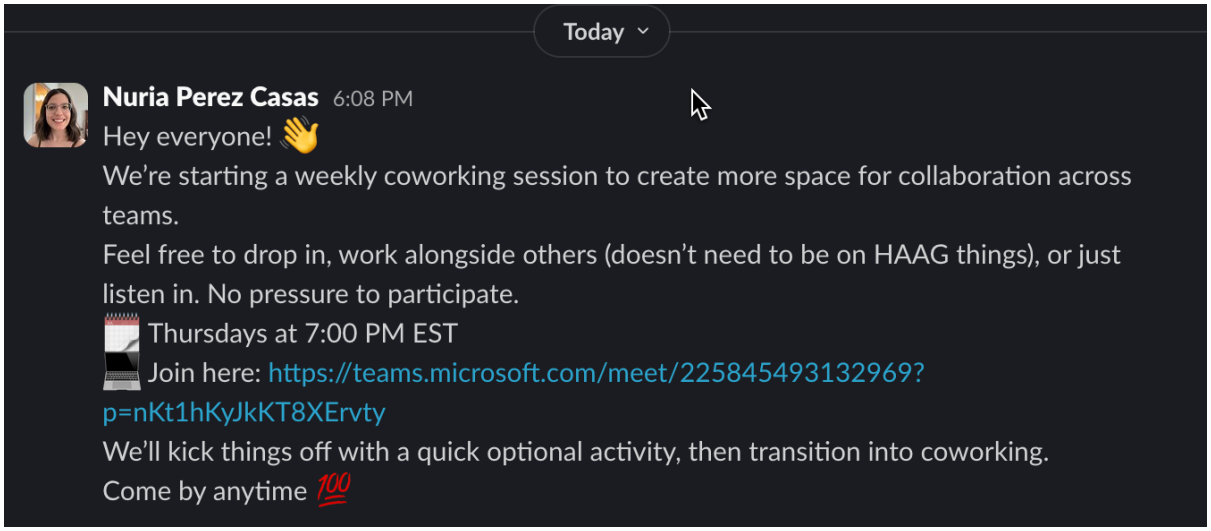
This process is designed to iterate easily into existing workflows and require minimal effort to maintain.

4. Procedure

Step 1: Set up the Session (5-10 Minutes)

- Select a consistent recurring time (Recommended weekly or biweekly). If you are open, you can send a poll to the general slack channel
- Create a calendar invite (within teams with Join Link)
- Share the link via Slack - HAAG General Channel

Guideline: Keep communication simple and low pressure. Emphasize flexibility.
Example: "Setting up a coworking session for people that are interested in working with other researchers and networking. Don't need to be working on HAAG related things. Drop in anytime, no pressure to participate."



Step 2: Prepare a Short Activity (5 Minutes)

Select one optional activity to start the session. The purpose is to reduce friction and awkwardness and encourage light interaction.

Guidelines:

- Keep under 5-10 minutes
- Participation is optional
- Avoid anything that feels forced or high-pressure

Step 3: Run the session (60-90 minutes total)

- Start on time with a brief welcome (2-3 minutes)
- Set expectations:
    - Participation is optional
    - Camera/mic use is optional
- Facilitate the activity
- Transition into coworking

During coworking:

- Minimize facilitation
- Allow natural interactions or silent work

At the end:

- Give people a 5 minute heads up that the session is going to end in 5 minutes
- Regroup and give people the opportunity to share what they worked on and any progress they've made.

Key Principle: The session should feel informal and flexible, not like a meeting.

Step 4: Track Participation (2-3 minutes post session)

Record:

- Approx attendance
- Repeat participants (if you know)
- Whether they stayed for coworking

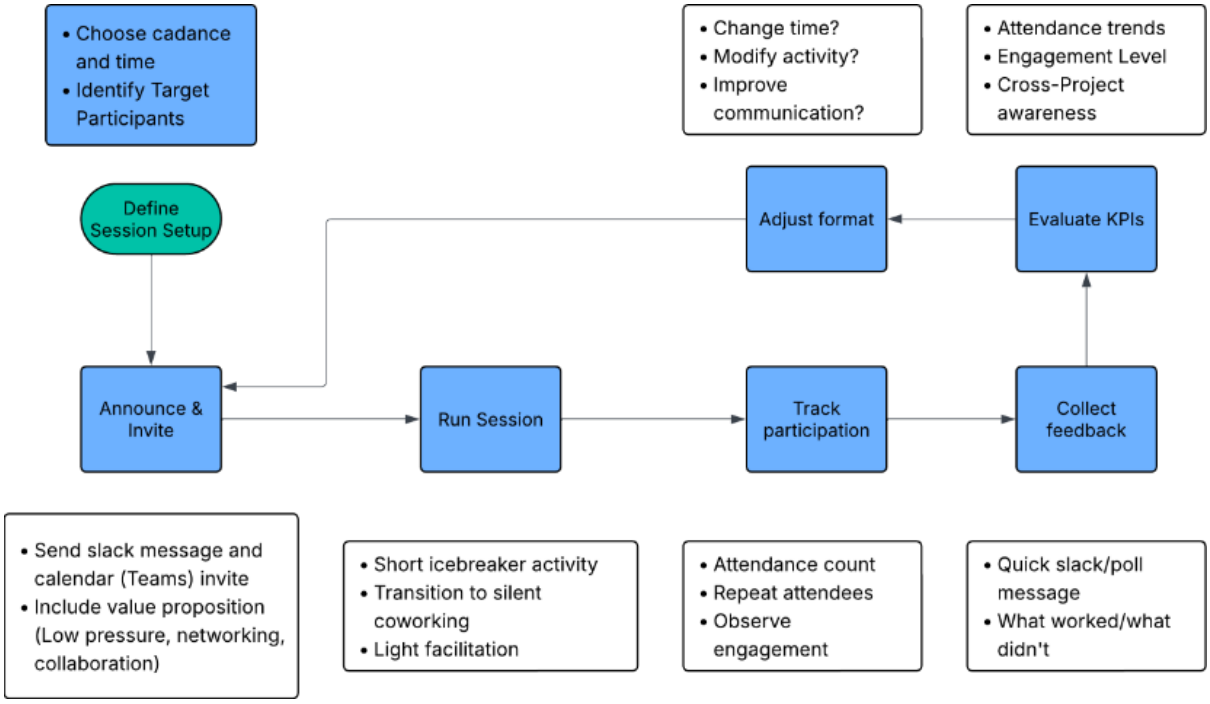
Optional:

- Ask for quick informal feedback. Slack Poll or conversation at the end

Step 5: Iterate and Improve (5 minutes)

Based on observations:

- Adjust timing if needed
- Rotate or modify activities
- Improve messaging or reminders



5. Example Activities

These are plug-and-play options that require minimal setup.

1. 1-Sentence Check-In

Each participant (optional) shares:

- "Today I'm working on ___"

Purpose: quick awareness of what others are doing

2. 2-Minute Project Share

- Pair participants (or small groups)
- Each person explains their project briefly

Purpose: cross-team understanding

3. Wikipedia Navigation Game (Wiki Race)

- Start on a random Wikipedia page
- Set a target page (e.g., "Artificial Intelligence")
- Goal: reach it in the fewest clicks

Purpose: low-stakes, fun interaction that encourages engagement

4. "Ask for Help" Prompt

Optional prompt:

- "What's one thing you're stuck on?"

Participants can respond or skip.

Purpose: surface collaboration opportunities

5. Silent Start (No Activity)

- Begin session with minimal intro
- Allow immediate coworking

Purpose: reduce friction for more established groups

6. Tools and Integrations

This procedure integrates directly into HAAG systems:

- Slack: announcements and reminders
- Calendar (Outlook): A recurring event can be set up and shared with interested participants
- Teams: Virtual Sessions

7. Effort and Time Commitment

- Setup: 5-10 minutes
- Facilitation: minimal during sessions
- Follow-up: 5 minutes

8. Sustainability and Handoff

- Any HAAG member can host a session using this SOP
- Facilitation can rotate weekly
- No specific knowledge is required

Optional:

- Maintain a shared recurring calendar event
- Assign rotating hosts (Don't need to to begin with)

9. Success Indicators

- Consistent or increasing attendance
- Repeat participation
- Observable cross-team interaction
- Informal collaboration/networking and knowledge sharing

10. Notes

This procedure prioritizes consistency and low friction over strict structure. Its effectiveness depends on making participation easy and finding intrinsic value in coworking sessions.